

COMETH THE HOUR, COMETH THE WOMAN

"Do women play games?" What a draconian thought, right? Women have always participated in video games since the industry's inception. The percentage of female participants may not be as high as men, but they've always formed a considerable section of the gaming fraternity. With the rise of smartphones, more and more female consumers are pouring in. Women are not only playing mere casual games but also "hardcore" games such as Call of Duty, World of Warcraft, DOTA and Counter Strike, among others

Here's an interesting question: Why do people think that the majority of women are not interested in playing social or mobile games? Maybe the lack of games with female protagonists is a reason. More often than not, the female characters in video games are showcased as damsels in distress or reinforce old stereotypes that no woman relates to. With time, we've furthered ourselves with technology and advanced methods of creating video games. And yet, the way female characters are designed remains quite outdated. Most female characters are stereotyped in the worst possible way, with heavy makeup, typically sculpted bodies with provocative clothes and high heels.

The tide is turning, though. Games these days are targeted towards mass audiences rather than gender-defined audiences or any other section, for that matter. Award-winning game *Journey's* protagonist is a faceless character without a specific gender,

culture or country. Also games like *Transistor* or *Child Of Light* are taken forward by female protagonists who move away from the usual stereotypes. They're fresh and creatively conceptualised characters who actually fit the storyline of the game. Such games lean towards being more of a "heroine's journey" than just female versions of a male specific/fantasy orientated game. This kind of fresh outlook on games, be it from any genre, works by targeting not only women but gamers of other age groups and races as well.

Women are not only consumers in the video game industry but also creators of these games. Though the percentage is not very high at the moment, it's slowly increasing. Besides joining as Game Artists, the number of female Game Designers and Programmers is gradually growing. People such as Kellee Santiago – Game Designer, Producer and Founder of 'ThatGameCompany', makers of the beautifully crafted, multi-award winning game *Journey* – can only be expected to pull in more female talent into the industry. As more such like-minded women enter the industry, Gaming is set to grow by leaps and bounds by being all-inclusive.

Written by Shruti Ghosh, a video game industry veteran of 7 years, who's currently a Game Art Trainer at DSKSIC. For more articles, visit dsk.digit.in

The competition in the smartphone market is intense in the sub-10k price range. Motorola revolutionised this space with premium-looking, good quality phones last year, changing the game and further stoking the flames of competition. Asus, Karbonn, Motorola, Xiaomi and Huawei, among many others have made legitimate claims on the consumer's pocket. But if there's one phone that impressed us above all else in this price segment, it has to be the Asus Zenfone 5. The phone has a dual-core Intel Atom SoC, with hyper-threading support leading to a fast-paced, breezy user experience. To top that, the Zenfone 5 offers an 8MP camera that's better than some 13MP shooters in the market. Add to this the fact that the phone's battery lasts you a full day very easily. The phone can't put a foot wrong to be honest.



ASUS Zenfone 5

Cabinet buying advice

Hi Agent 001, I'm in a conundrum. I don't want to buy a mini PC off-the-shelf. I want to build it myself. Can you suggest the best mini-ITX motherboard and cabinet to realise this dream? Also, a round-up of the best cabinets in all price brackets and form factors would be greatly appreciated?

– Sid Shah

Building an HTPC by yourself is a good idea as you'll have plenty of options to choose from. Since you've not mentioned any particular price point, we'll suggest three different options. If you're cash strapped, you should consider getting a motherboard with an embedded CPU such as the Gigabyte GA-J1800N-D2H for ₹4,000 based on the Intel Celeron J1800 chipset, however, keep in mind that it won't be upgradeable in the future. If you want something from the mid-range price bracket, the ASRock Z87E-ITX available for ₹13,350 is an excellent motherboard to go for. House it in the Cooler Master Elite 120 Advanced Mini-ITX case for ₹2,499 and you're set. If you don't have a limited budget, go for the Asus Maximus VII Impact as it's one of the best boards out there with a ton of options. As for the case, get the Bitfenix Prodigy M for ₹6,200 and you'll have a winner on your hands.

Help me pick an HDMI streamer

Dear Agent 001, I basically want to stream content from my tablet, smartphone or laptop onto my 32-inch high-definition television. I've researched a little bit about Miracast dongles. Please help me pick the best one. I trust your decision wholeheartedly in this matter.

– Meet Brar

You haven't mentioned a budget so we'll go through two options. EZCast based streamers are pretty feature rich at lower price points or for a little more money check out Roku's Streamer Stick and get a proxy DNS service like Unlocator.